Italian Wedding Soup with Acini di Pepe

Beef and pork meatballs, vegetables, tiny pasta and spinach.

SERVES 6 · MAKES ABOUT 12 CUPS · TOTAL 50 MIN

INGREDIENTS

Meatballs

8 oz	lean ground beef (80 to 90% lean)
8 oz	ground pork
1/2 cup	fresh bread crumbs, not dried (1 slice rustic bread, ground in a food processor)
1/4 cup	fresh parsley, chopped
1 1/2 tsp	fresh oregano, minced (or 3/4 tsp dried)
1/2 cup	Parmesan, finely shredded
1	large egg
1 tsp	salt
1/4 tsp	black pepper, freshly ground
1 tbsp	olive oil, for browning

Soup

1 tbsp	olive oil
1 1/4 cups	carrots, chopped
1 1/4 cups	yellow onion, chopped
3/4 cup	celery, chopped
4 cloves	garlic, minced (1 1/2 tbsp)
8 3/4 cups	low-sodium chicken broth or chicken bone broth (about 70 oz)
	salt and black pepper, to taste
1 cup	dry acini di pepe or orzo
6 oz	baby spinach, roughly chopped

To serve

	Parmesan, finely shredded

METHOD

1. Combine the beef, pork, bread crumbs, parsley, oregano, Parmesan, egg, 1 tsp salt and 1/4 tsp pepper. Toss gently with your hands until evenly mixed. Roll into 3/4 to 1 inch balls, small enough to fit a spoon and spread evenly.

2. Heat 1 tbsp oil in a large nonstick skillet over medium-high. Brown half the meatballs, turning to color 2 or 3 sides, about **4 minutes**; two batches leave them room to brown. Drain on paper towels, keep the oil in the pan, and repeat. They finish cooking in the soup.

3. Meanwhile, heat 1 tbsp oil in a large pot over medium-high. Sauté the carrots, onion and celery until soft, **6 to 8 minutes**; add the garlic for **1 minute**.

4. Add the broth, season with salt and pepper, and bring to a boil. Stir in the pasta and meatballs and lower the heat to medium-low.

5. Cover and simmer, stirring now and then, until the pasta is tender and the meatballs are cooked through, about **10 minutes**. Stir in the spinach for the last **1 minute**.

6. Serve hot, with Parmesan over each bowl.

NOTES

Make ahead & storage

- Keeps up to **3 days** refrigerated, airtight, or **3 months** frozen. The pasta keeps absorbing broth as it sits, so thin leftovers with more broth.
- Reader tip: cook the pasta separately and add it to each bowl if you want it to stay al dente.

Substitutions

- Dried, shelf-stable crumbs throw off the meatballs' texture; fresh ones from a hearty loaf work best. Italian bread or sourdough (faintly tangy) both work; trim thick crust and measure the 1/2 cup, since slices vary.
- No ground pork: use another 8 oz ground beef.
- No celery: use 3/4 cup chopped fennel bulb or celery root, or leave it out and add 1/4 tsp celery seed with the garlic.
- Acini di pepe is the first choice. Orzo, ditalini, pastina stars or macaroni also work. For a brothier soup, cut the pasta to 3/4 cup.
- Kale, endive or escarole can replace the spinach. Add them with the pasta, since they need far longer than spinach.
- Chicken bone broth makes a richer, fuller-bodied soup. Sodium varies by brand, so taste before salting. Leftovers may gel when chilled; they loosen on reheating.
- For more depth, use homemade stock, simmer a Parmesan rind in the pot, or add fresh basil.

Pairs with

- Homemade Acini di Pepe. Fresh beads cook faster than dried, so stir them in for the last **5 minutes**.

My notes

- Sartori SarVecchio, a Wisconsin Parmesan aged **20+ months**, worked very well in place of Parmigiano Reggiano.

PER SERVING

396 cal · 29 g protein · 20 g fat · 6 g sat fat · 25 g carbs · 3 g fiber · 362 mg sodium · 4 g sugar

OLIVE OIL, TOMATO & HERB
PROTEIN MAIN · BROWN, THEN SIMMER

Adapted from Jaclyn, Cooking Classy (cookingclassy.com). Method rewritten and condensed for personal kitchen use.